

CORE FORMULA

State what you share -> Build the common ground -> Then diverge clearly

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before presenting your counter-argument, name one specific thing you agree with in their position. Then state your difference.

BEST FOR

- Conversations where the relationship matters as much as the outcome
- Negotiations and collaborative problem-solving
- Presenting alternative views without triggering defensiveness
- Building trust while disagreeing

PHRASE BANK

Shared Ground · Naming what you have in common

- "We are both trying to solve the same problem."
- "We agree on the goal — we differ on the method."
- "I share the concern — I just see a different solution."
- "The outcome we both want is the same."
- "We both want this to work."
- "The principle behind what you are saying is one I agree with."
- "We are on the same side here."
- "I am not arguing against your goal — I am arguing for a different path."

Disagreement Bridge · Pivoting to the difference

- "Where I diverge is on the approach."
- "The part I see differently is how to get there."
- "My concern is specifically about the method, not the aim."
- "I agree with the destination — I question the route."
- "The difference is a narrow but important one."

Warm Common Ground · Differences inside close relationships

- "I am on your side in this — I just see one part differently."
- "Before anything else: I understand why this matters to you, and it matters to me too."
- "We want the same thing for the kids — where we differ is how to get there."
- "None of this changes how much I value what you are doing."
- "I agree with your instinct. It is the plan I want to push on."
- "You and I are after the same future — this is only about the route."

Structured Agreement · Precise common ground in work settings

- "Let me start with where the proposal is right — because most of it is."
- "I agree with the problem statement and two of the three recommendations."
- "There is a lot of common ground here, so let me be precise about the one gap."
- "The analysis is sound — my challenge is only to the conclusion drawn from it."
- "I support the direction. I want to stress-test one assumption before we commit."
- "We agree on the goal and the budget. The open question is sequencing."

Agreement Under Fire · Granting the premise before the challenge

- "You are right that the risk is real — and that is exactly why I favour the other option."
- "I grant the premise fully. It is the conclusion I cannot follow you to."
- "We agree this decision is critical — which is why I cannot stay quiet on this point."
- "I accept every fact you have laid out. My disagreement is about what they mean."
- "We want the same result for this company. On this decision, I believe you are wrong."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Launching immediately into your counter-position
Better: Before I disagree — we do agree on X.
Best: Name one specific, genuine shared goal or value before stating the difference.
2. Weak: Manufactured agreement that sounds insincere
Better: I can see we have some common ground.
Best: Specific, true agreement that both parties recognise as real.
3. Weak: Agreeing on everything and then failing to disagree
Better: I have one concern with the approach.
Best: Clear shared ground, clear transition, clear statement of difference.

DECISION TREE

If You disagree but want to keep a collaborative tone

Build the shared ground first. Then name the difference.

"We both want this to succeed. Where I see it differently is on the approach."

If The other person is treating you as an adversary

Name the shared goal explicitly to reframe the dynamic.

"We are solving for the same thing — I want to make sure we are not arguing against each other."

If You cannot find genuine shared ground

Do not fabricate it. Be honest that you are starting from different places.

"I do not think we share the starting assumption here — which might be why we differ."

If The shared ground is used too much and becomes hollow

Use it sparingly — only when it is genuinely true.

SCENARIOS

Negotiation where both sides are defensive

Name the shared goal before stating your position. — "We both want a deal that works. Let me say where I think we can find that."

Team debate where sides are forming

Name what everyone agrees on to shift the dynamic. — "Before we get into the disagreement — I think we all agree on X. Everything else is how."

Presenting a different view to a senior stakeholder

Open with the shared goal. Then present your alternative. — "I am arguing for the same outcome you are. My concern is that this path does not get us there."

Conflict with a close colleague or partner

Name the shared relationship goal before the specific disagreement. — "We both want this to work. That is why I need to say something about it."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When a harmful or unethical direction requires speed of objection over tone.
- When you have already agreed in principle and additional agreement feels performative.
- In one-on-one contexts where the group dynamic element is absent — consider TC001 instead.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Find the shared goal

In one disagreement today, identify the goal you both share before stating your position.

Day 2 — Name it aloud

In one conversation, explicitly say: 'We both want X' before stating your counter-position.

Day 3 — Genuine vs manufactured

Check that your agreement is real. If it is not, do not use it.

Day 4 — Keep the disagreement clear

After naming the shared ground, state your difference clearly — do not let the agreement swallow your position.

Day 5 — Use in a negotiation

Use the technique in one situation where you are on opposing sides of something.

Day 6 — Notice the tone

In one use of this technique, notice how the tone of the conversation changes after you name shared ground.

Day 7 — Calibration

Were your disagreements received better? Did any shared ground feel hollow? Did your position still land?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I identify genuine shared ground before stating my difference?
- Was the agreement specific — not generic?
- Did I state my disagreement clearly after the shared ground?
- Did the conversation feel collaborative rather than adversarial?
- Did I avoid using the agreement to avoid disagreeing?
- Was my agreement genuine rather than performative?
- Did the other person recognise the shared ground as real?